2 | Partition and Civil War 1947–8

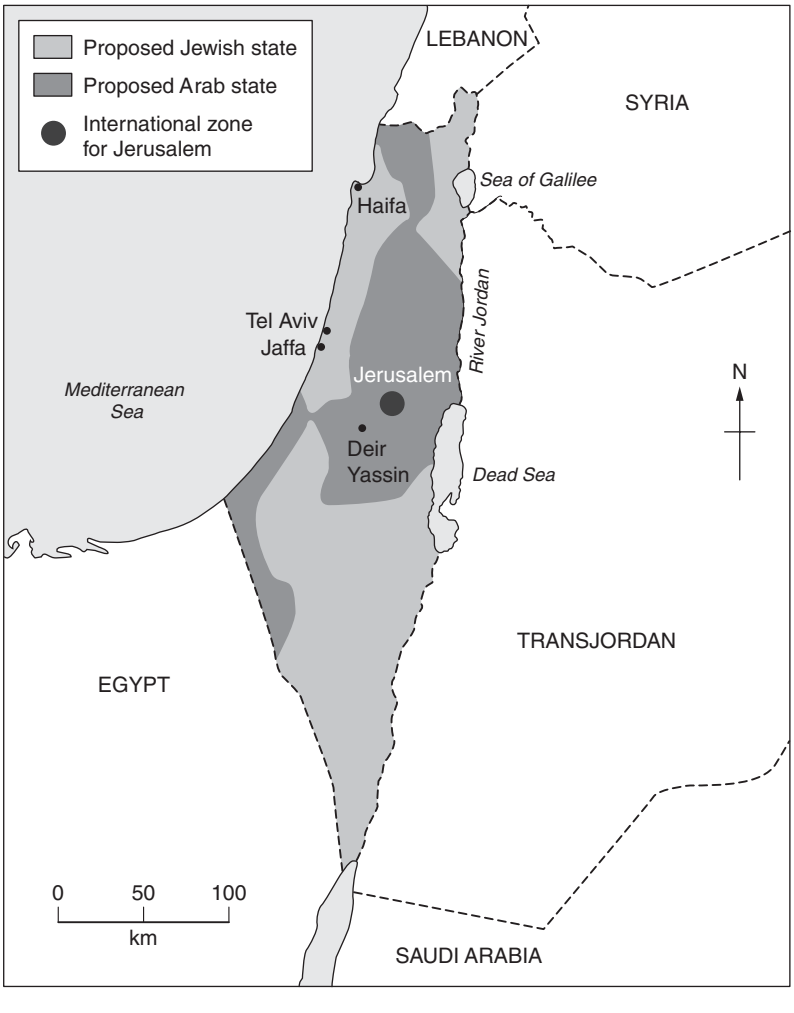
UN vote for partition, November 1947

Key question
What was the response to the UNSCOP report?

As early as February 1947 the British government sought the advice of the UN which had been formed at the end of the Second World War. The UN Special Committee on Palestine (UNSCOP) was set up to investigate, and then make recommendations on how to resolve, the Palestine problem. The UNSCOP report was completed in August and, three months later, in November, the **UN General Assembly** voted to accept its recommendations. The main recommendation was to divide Palestine and set up both a Jewish and an Arab state. The areas that were more Jewish (in population and land ownership) were to be allocated to the Jewish state and those which were mainly Arab to the Arab state. As you can see on the map below, this resulted in a criss-cross arrangement with 'kissing points' at the intersections. The UN thought that this would force the two sides to co-operate! The holy city of Jerusalem was to be an international zone governed by an international force.

Key date
United Nations vote for partition of Palestine: November 1947

Key term
UN General Assembly
The main body of the UN in which every state is represented.



The UN partition plan. What problems might you expect in a state divided into three parts?